gather splinters from fence sitting, proclaimed that we would beat the Australians 10–0: not bad going in a five-Test series.

We were in a pretty good place as a team but weren't from another planet. Australia weren't Luton Town, my team, turning up at Manchester City in damage-limitation mode. Margins were narrow and matches were decided by players who possessed the confidence and experience to seize the moment. The first Test, at Trent Bridge, was a kaleidoscopic example of long-form cricket.

The fairytale of Ashton Agar, the teenaged tail-ender who made 98 in his first Test innings, didn't quite make it to the publisher. Stuart Broad somehow made himself a marked man by refusing to walk when an edge ricocheted to slip from the gloves of wicketkeeper Brad Haddin. Jimmy Anderson, another Aussie irritant, bowled himself to the point of exhaustion on a slow, low pitch before his tenth wicket of the match, confirmed by DRS, clinched a fourteen-run victory.

We ran around like headless chickens, but the quietest member of the group had made the biggest noise. Ian Bell came of age in that series, scoring the first of three centuries at Nottingham and raising his game to a different level. He was a beautiful player, an aesthetically pleasing cover driver, but naturally insecure and easily overshadowed.

It takes strength to admit weakness but, by working with Mark Bawden, he reached his optimal level. He was sensational, almost lyrical on occasion, but as someone saddled by expectation since the age of sixteen, when he was selected for England A, he was temperamentally a slow burn.

It took time, and careful self-analysis, for the golden child to truly believe in himself. He acknowledged the pressure, rationalized it, delivered and dominated. I owed him so much because appearances were deceptive. The win by an innings in the second Test at Lord's, where Belly changed the tenor of the match by scoring 109 after coming in at 28–3, signalled the beginning of the end for that team.

We never again reproduced the ruthlessness that spawned articles with headlines such as 'How Does One Beat a Team of Robots?' The journalist, who had evidently decided to flog the analogy to death, suggested removing my battery, apparently inserted by ECB scientists. He hoped fervently that I would be found, wandering around, intoning, 'Does not compute! Does not compute! Error! Error!'